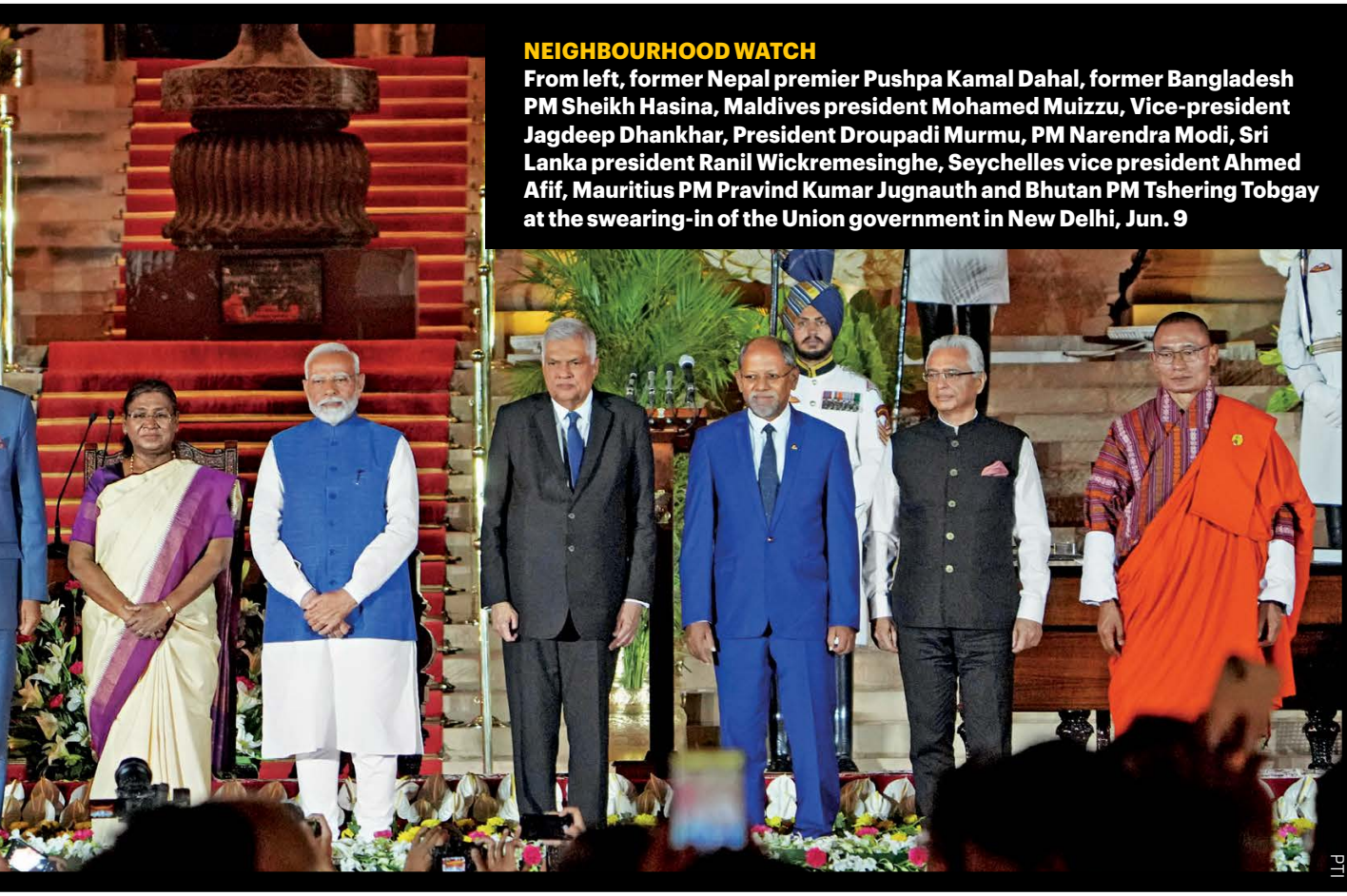


NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH
From left, former Nepal premier Pushpa Kamal Dahal, former Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina, Maldives president Mohamed Muizzu, Vice-president Jagdeep Dhankhar, President Droupadi Murmu, PM Narendra Modi, Sri Lanka president Ranil Wickremesinghe, Seychelles vice president Ahmed Afif, Mauritius PM Pravind Kumar Jugnauth and Bhutan PM Tshering Tobgay at the swearing-in of the Union government in New Delhi, Jun. 9

PTI



"OUR NEIGHBOURHOOD IS IMPLODING. THIS IS GOING TO BE INDIA'S NUMBER ONE FOREIGN POLICY PRIORITY AND WE MUST GO BACK TO THE DRAWING BOARD"

–ARVIND GUPTA *Director, Vivekananda Foundation*

India was afraid that any sort of intensification of her vulnerability would open the door either to the Islamist Opposition that does not wish India well in any case or to exploitation by China. The policy worked when Hasina controlled the reins of power. But the moment the domestic cataclysm ended up with her being on the out, Delhi's entire Bangladesh policy has come apart and come under criticism about its direction."

INDIA'S NEIGHBOURHOOD CURSE

Tellis, though, is sympathetic to New Delhi's predicament and says "India's curse" is that it is surrounded by countries riven by deep domestic political cleavages. This results in a constant yo-yo-like relationship with these nations. So, there is a dramatic improvement in relations when pro-India parties come to power, but things go rapidly downhill when alternative political forces gain ground. What has compounded the problem is that some of India's neighbours are relatively new nation-states—Bangladesh itself came into existence only in 1971, just 53 years ago. Former National Security Advisor Shivshankar Menon points out that not only does India have a huge presence in the region, it also has tremendous influence both economically and in terms of society and tradition. Pakistan may be the only partial exception, since its identity and existence are self-defined by its difference with India. Menon recalls how Gen. Zia-ul-Haq, who ruled Pakistan in the 1980s, when asked why he was pushing for greater Islamisation of his country, reportedly said, "If an Egyptian stops being a Muslim, he still remains an Egyptian. But if a Pakistani stops being a Muslim, he becomes an Indian." Menon's point: Every new nation-state needs to have a perceived enemy to unify its citizens against it. The less the basis for the creation of a nation-state, the more antagonistic it will need to appear. And India is encircled by such nascent nations.

Take Bangladesh. It shares an over 4,000-km land border with India, the longest we have with any neighbour. It is situated east of where West Bengal abuts the Northeast through the narrow but critical Siliguri corridor, rendering it of vital strategic importance to India. But after the